

Tamil, the language in which he can express his complex financial and operational insights best.

"We encourage him to communicate in the language he is most comfortable with," says Kumar. "There is always somebody who can translate, but nobody can replace the knowledge and passion he brings to the room. He has been promoted twice in the last three years. Capability takes precedence over language proficiency."

The question is becoming more urgent as corporate India hires deeper into Tier-II and Tier-III cities: does English fluency determine leadership potential, or has it simply become a convenient proxy?

WHERE ENGLISH MATTERS

In white-collar corporate environments, English's role varies dramatically by an employee's career stage, functional responsibilities, and market focus.

At the entry level, English frequently acts as a filter during high-volume campus recruitment and initial screening.

Chetan Mangalwedhe, Founder & CEO of executive search firm TalentiFi-X, observes: "English still matters most at the gate. In the global capability centre (GCC) and product roles we fill, it is used to screen campus and junior candidates more than it is used to judge who can actually do the job."

Some founders are rethinking that bias. Kanan Bahl, founder of Fingrowth Media, interviewed a Tier-II candidate whose spoken English was poor, but whose technical sample was exceptional.

Despite initial hesitation over client interaction, Bahl hired him, allowed him to work with clients in regional languages, and later described him as his best hire.

While many organisations still struggle to look past linguistic polish, a handful of forward thinking major firms are actively decoupling core potential from spoken English.

"We are positive about the depth of skill, aspiration, and drive across Bharat, and we continue to broaden access to talent, reaching into Tier-II and -III centres," says Deepti Sagar, Chief People and Experience Officer at Deloitte India. Sagar emphasises that language strategies must balance global client delivery with regional realities. Deloitte is an Indian organisation and part of a diverse global

▶ With over 60% of engineering graduates coming from non-metro regions, companies risk missing out on top-tier, highly motivated talent by over-indexing on language skills early on

▶ Leading management institutes find that language barriers among vernacular-medium students are temporary, favouring peer learning and targeted support over full bilingual degree programmes

▶ Emerging AI translation tools are reducing communication friction, shifting the focus across corporate India from rigid language compliance to core intellectual capability and impact